A SUMMARY OF THE ENTIRE HILCHOT SHABBAT IN 14 CLASSES

The Shabbat Kitchen Part 3: Threshing and Selecting

Class 5 of 14

Series: Laws of Shabbat — a 14-part course

Shiur: 5 of 14

Topic: The Shabbat Kitchen, Part 3 — Dash (Threshing) and Borer (Selecting)

Recorded: Tiferet Eyal, Hendon — 20 November 2018

Recap

So far: an introduction to Shabbat and Erev Shabbat; Kiddush, the meals and Havdala; and two weeks on Bishul — cooking, and what may be left on or returned to the fire. Tonight, two more major melachot: **Dash** (threshing) and **Borer** (selecting).

Part A — Dash (Threshing)

The definition

In the Mishkan, seeds were extracted from their pods to make the dye for the lowest roof covering. So **Dash = extracting something from an inedible casing** — or extracting something that was inaccessible before.

- Opening an edible pod (e.g. green sugar-snap style pods) and taking out the edible beans — **permitted**: both are food.
- Extracting kernels of wheat from the husk — the classic Dash, **forbidden**.

1. Squeezing fruit and vegetables

Squeezing a liquid out of a fruit extracts something previously inaccessible — a form of Dash.

Fruit	Status
Grapes and olives	Forbidden by the **Torah** — the only truly significant drinks (compare the price of grape juice and olive oil with apple juice)
Fruit and vegetables commonly squeezed for juice (orange, apple, pear, pineapple, tomato)	Forbidden **rabbinically** — similar to grapes and olives
Produce rarely squeezed (e.g. melon)	Permitted

The Rabbi recalled once being offered melon juice in the home of someone on a special diet — it exists, but is not common. Carrot juice involves other issues (grinding) and its status is debatable.

Squeezing between the lips

- **Inside the mouth**, while eating — no melacha at all; that is the normal way of eating.
- **Squeezing by hand into the mouth** — forbidden.
- **Sucking juice out between the lips** (not while eating) — debated. Halacha: avoid with **grapes and olives** (a Torah prohibition is at stake); **permitted** with other fruit (strawberry, orange segment).

Squeezing directly onto food

Cutting a fruit into pieces is never Dash. Juice squeezed **directly onto solid food** (e.g. orange onto a fruit salad) never takes on an identity as a liquid — it goes from solid to solid — so it is **permitted for any fruit**. But squeezing into a cup and then pouring onto the salad is **not**; it must go straight onto the food.

Lemons

The Shulchan Aruch, in one of its shortest rulings: **מותר לסחוט לימון"ש** — *one may squeeze lemons.* Even into an empty cup. Lemon juice is not drunk on its own — it is always added to something — so it is not comparable to grapes and olives. By hand only, not with a squeezer or machine. One may squeeze lemon straight into tea — preferably into a **kli shlishi**, as lemon may be a "tender" food for Bishul purposes; strictly a kli sheni is fine.

Peeling fruit

Isn't peeling an orange extracting the fruit from an inedible case? No — **peeling is permitted**. The action is on the peel, removing it to expose the fruit, rather than extracting the fruit from its case (among other reasons).

2. Milking — animals, and expressing milk

Milking an animal is **Dash from the Torah**. But **tza'ar ba'alei chayim** — preventing animal suffering — is also a Torah mitzvah. If an animal is in pain from not being milked:

1. Ask a **non-Jew** to milk it — even directly; instructing a non-Jew is only rabbinic.
2. If none is available, a Jew may milk it **to waste**: a melacha with no constructive purpose (*mekalkel*) is only rabbinically forbidden — permitted to relieve the animal.
3. Use an electric milking machine on a **timer**: attach it while off; when it switches on, it is only **gerama** (indirect) — and the milk may be kept. If the machine is already running, let the first drops (directly caused by attaching it) go to waste; the rest is gerama.

A nursing mother in discomfort is in exactly the same position: she may express to waste; if the baby needs the milk, use a timer-operated pump as above. Without one, seek rabbinic guidance.

Q (milk from Mehadrin dairies milked electrically on Shabbat): no reason it may not be used. If a non-Jew milks the cows while a Jew watches, it is still *chalav Yisrael*.

3. Crushing ice, snow and hail

The Gemara forbids crushing **ice, snow or hail** on Shabbat. Reasons: it resembles Dash (turning a solid into liquid — rabbinic, since nothing is extracted from a case); the Rambam sees it as *Makeh Be'Patish* / "creating" new water. Either way:

- Only the **act** of crushing is forbidden. Ice cubes in a drink, or a tray of ice left on the table to melt — **permitted**.
- Don't crush ice cubes against the side of the glass with a spoon.
- **Making ice** (liquid → solid) is fine — but only for use on that Shabbat, not for Motzei Shabbat or the following week.
- Automatic electric ice-makers raise electrical issues (to be discussed separately).

Using a bar of soap

Two concerns: turning a solid into a liquid, and **smoothing** (*memare'ach*) the bar. Chacham Ovadia: dissolving by rubbing isn't creating a liquid; smoothing here is an unintended, purely cosmetic effect (a rabbinic *pesik reisha delo nicha lei*). So Sephardim **may use a bar of soap** — but where liquid soap is available, use it. (Ashkenazim have additional issues.)

Part B — Borer (Selecting)

The definition

Borer = selecting an item out of a mixture. (A lesson in itself: you may walk for hours on Shabbat, but organising and categorising — an industrial process — is forbidden.)

Selection becomes permitted — a form of eating rather than an industrial act — when **three conditions** are met:

1. **Take the good from the bad** — "bad" just means what you don't want now. From a bowl of mixed nuts, take out the almonds you want; don't remove the peanuts and walnuts you don't.
2. **By hand** — a fork or spoon counts as an extension of the hand. A specialist tool does not: peeling a potato with a knife is fine; with a **peeler**, avoid.
3. **For immediate use** — within about half an hour, or for the **upcoming meal**. Preparing dessert half an hour before sitting down is fine, even if eaten three hours later. Preparing it at 9 am before going to shul for a lunch hours later — avoid.

No mixture, no Borer

The most important principle. A bowl of identical apples may be divided — that is **division, not selection**. Hence:

- **Bones from fish or chicken** — a piece of salmon is one entity, not "salmon mixed with bones" (Mishnah Berurah). You may remove the bones, even for later. But once plates are cleared and leftover fish and bones are piled together, that *is* a new mixture.
- **Chicken skin** — same idea; but loose skins mixed back together become a mixture.
- **Watermelon seeds** may be removed (even the Ben Ish Chai is lenient).
- **Pomegranate** — opening it and taking out seeds is neither Dash (you're opening the outer case) nor Borer (one entity). Once seeds and white pith are loose in a bowl, it is a mixture.
- **Tinned tuna in oil** — a mixture: take the tuna out; don't drain the oil (unless you want the oil).
- A platter of **different fish balls** (cod, salmon…) — a mixture.
- Large items clearly visible on a table (apples and oranges) — not a mixture.

Sorting cutlery

After Friday night dinner, 20 knives, forks and spoons are mixed together. Sorting them isn't "good from bad" — you want them all, just later. Some see organising as Borer; others require selection. Combined with further reasons to be lenient (a view that "bad" not truly bad is only an issue beyond the upcoming meal; and that big, clearly distinguishable utensils may not be a mixture at all), Chacham Ovadia permits **washing up on Friday night and sorting the cutlery to set the table for Shabbat morning** — for the next meal only, not for Se'udah Shlishit. If some of it (e.g. special guest cutlery) won't be used in the morning, it becomes good-from-bad and is forbidden.

Q: Does *tircha* (effort) matter? — That concept applies to Borer on Yom Tov, not Shabbat.

Solid and liquid

A carrot sitting in chicken soup is not "mixed" with it — a solid and a liquid are clearly distinct. So one may remove an unwanted carrot from soup (*ein Borer be'ochlin u'mashkin* in this sense). Two liquids together would be a mixture.

Only an active act of selection

The Mishnah: carrying a trough that incidentally sifts the food is permitted — Borer requires a deliberate act of selection, and *pesik reisha* doesn't apply here. So a **salt shaker with rice inside** may be used; the sieve holding back the rice isn't your act of selecting.

Borer applies to **non-food items** too: toys, and **playing cards** — similar cards (same number and colour, different suit) may form a mixture; think games through before playing.

Questions from the floor

- **Searching through a pile of tallitot** in shul for a good one — permitted: you are randomly picking up and putting aside to reach what you want, not performing an act of selection. Likewise lifting coats off a hook to reach yours.
- **Sorting books** — books with visible titles are not a mixture; identical unmarked books would be.

Summary

- **Dash** = extracting from an inedible casing. Squeezing grapes and olives — Torah; commonly juiced fruit — rabbinic.
- Squeezing **directly onto food** is permitted for any fruit; **lemons** may be squeezed even into a cup. Peeling is fine.
- Milking / expressing: non-Jew; to waste; or a timer-operated machine.
- Don't **crush** ice or snow; letting it melt or making ice for Shabbat is fine. Bar soap permitted for Sephardim; liquid soap preferable.
- **Borer** needs a mixture; permitted with good-from-bad, by hand, for immediate use. Bones, skin, watermelon seeds — not a mixture. Cutlery may be sorted on Friday night for the morning meal.

Coming Up

Shiur 6 — 27 November: The Shabbat Kitchen, Part 4 — Grinding, Kneading and Pickling

- Mashing eggs, liver, cheese, avocado

- Making tehina; pickling food on Shabbat

After that, a break for Chanukah; the series resumes on 18 December.

B'Ezrat Hashem

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